vari, in north Telangana, daily for the *aksharabhyasam* ritual. The CM performed another ritual, launching a Rs 225 crore expansion that will treble built-up area at the complex to a pilgrim-friendly 62,000 sq. ft, with spacious queue zones.

In March, he set the ball rolling at the centuries-old Sri Sita Ramachandraswamy Temple in Bhadrachalam, on the Andhra border—also attending the annual *kalyanam* (wedding) ceremony that draws throngs from both Telugu states. Phase 1 will see upscaled ghats by June 2027, in time for the once-in-12-years Godavari *pushkaram*.

Also in March, the CM launched a Rs 700 crore facelift of the Omkareshwara and Veerabhadra Swamy temples at Manchirevula, off Hyderabad; part of his Musi riverfront project, the complex is pegged as the 'Kashi of the South'. Central Telangana's Vemulawada, the first temple town to get on the renovation chariot (in 2024), is chasing its ambition to be a pilgrim magnet too.

Takeaways

- **Revanth on pan-Telangana temple renovation spree**
- **Major, minor shrines to link up in four key pilgrim circuits**


Sita Ramachandraswamy temple

KARMA BEGINS AT HOME

Once done, these temples, with imposing granite *prakarams* and huge *rajagopurams*, would last centuries, say endowment officials. Revanth's pilgrim push entails four major circuits, linking key sites. His endowments haven't bypassed home. In 2025, the CM drafted blueprints for revamping the Sri Mahalakshmi Venkateswara Swamy temple, known locally as '*chinna*' (mini) Tirupati, as well as temples in Daulatabad and Kosgi—all in his south Telangana constituency Kodangal. But his drawing board is drawing ever-wider circles. Take the planned *mada-veedhis* (car-streets) at Warangal's Bhadrakali temple, or the amenities at the hilltop Kondagattu Sri Anjaneya Swamy temple. Together, Revanth's temple spree is said to easily surpass his predecessor K. Chandrasekhar Rao's Rs 1,500 crore Yadagirigutta upgrade.

In a moment of campaign heat, during the Jubilee Hills bypoll in 2025, Revanth had put his party in a pickle by saying, "Congress means Muslims and Muslims means Congress." In March, he atoned with the words: "I am a staunch, practising Hindu, who believes in *karma*."

His confidants echo that. Unlike KCR's Yadagiri fixation, Revanth is developing temples from Basara, abutting Maharashtra, right up to Andhra, says Vemulawada MLA and Congress whip Aadi Srinivas. "The BJP's approach is electoral. Our CM, while sticking to secularism, does far greater service to the faith he practises," he tells INDIA TODAY.

The BJP, unwilling to cede turf, pins him down to his faux pas. In December, the CM had said, "Hinduism has three crore deities. For celibates, there's Hanuman, for bigamists, there's another god, for those fond of alcohol, there's another..." For the BJP, levity cancels piety. Leader Alleti Maheshwar Reddy also cites a substantial hike in minority welfare funds, while others in the party bring up Revanth's unmet poll promise of a "100 Rama temples". ■

▶ MAHARASHTRA

Quotas Within Quota

The volatile debate over SC sub-categorisation sharpens in the state. In special focus is the Buddhist Dalit cohort

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

BEFORE CASTE QUOTAS RETURN to the national headlines with the Census, Maharashtra is offering a sneak preview of the wars that lie ahead—with a proposed quota within a quota for Dalits. The siege is on the very birthplace of reservations in India, centred around Buddhist Dalits, the erstwhile Mahars, who exited Hinduism with Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar in 1956. So the chief question is on uneven development within Dalit communities, but a volatile subclause has been tagged: religion.

The Scheduled Castes have a 13 per cent quota. In 2011, they numbered around 13.2 million out of Maharashtra's 112.3 million population. Hindu Dalit bodies allege Buddhist Dalits, the largest sub-bloc at about 60 per cent, secure most of the benefits; the latter refute this narrative.

'HINDU VS BUDDHIST'

This old debate will now be addressed within a formal process. In March, a one-man committee under former Patna High Court judge Anant Manohar Badar submitted its report on sub-categorisation of SC reservations. The state has ap-